Katsu Dojo Shito-Ryu Black Belt (Shodan) Study Guide

Based on the Katsu Dojo Digital Textbook (katsudojo.com). An unofficial study aid; your Sensei's instructions always come first.

Black Belt (Shodan) Requirements

- Perform **every basic exercise and every kata** listed in the textbook (all 14 kata).
- Take **all the written tests** in the textbook and score **100%**. From Green/White up, these are given **orally** in class the Monday or Tuesday before the test, using all the written questions in random order. Every answer must be correct.
- Other areas of the student's progression, both mental and physical, will be tested. The black belt test is private: only black belts may attend.
- **Age:** students 16 and older test for **Shodan** (1st Degree). Under 16 test for **Shodan-Ho** (Junior 1st Degree), unless an exception is made for superior ability and dedication. Junior black belts may not sit on the testing board, take part in the black belt test, or receive the title of Sensei.
- **Attendance:** attend almost all advanced classes in the months before the test, and help in beginner and intermediate classes.
- **Instructor review:** in the last two weeks before the test, your instructor reviews all requirements for your level, plus your attitude, manners, out-of-class behavior and school performance. Students who don't follow the five Katsu Dojo Virtues may not test.

Confirm with Sensei

- The minimum number of classes required at each belt level (the textbook says a minimum is required but gives no number).
- Whether every rank still uses the same Tanren Ho counts (the book lists 10 of each at every rank).
- Meaning of Sachin-dachi (listed as a stance from Green/Brown up, but not defined in the written tests).
- The Green Belt kanji question (the characters for Japan / kara / te) — practise from the printed textbook.
- The details of Take Down #7, Moving Exercise #2 and the Todi; the textbook only gives the quiz answers.
- How many rounds of Jyu Kumite, and what other 'mental and physical' areas, are tested at black belt.
- Whether kobudo (weapons) is part of the black belt test — the textbook's testing section does not list it.

The 14 Kata (in order)

1 Shiho No Kata *Four Direction Kata*	**2 Ten No Kata** *Heavenly Kata*	**3 Kihon No Kata** *Basic Kata*
4 Chi No Kata *Earth Kata*	**5 Heian Shodan** *Peaceful Mind #1*	**6 Heian Nidan** *Peaceful Mind #2*
7 Heian Sandan *Peaceful Mind #3*	**8 Heian Yondan** *Peaceful Mind #4*	**9 Heian Godan** *Peaceful Mind #5*
10 Jitte *Ten Hands*	**11 Jin** *Named after a spirit*	**12 Jion** *Named after a temple in China (its temple of origin)*
13 Jyuroku *Sixteen*	**14 Rohai** *Vision of a white heron*	

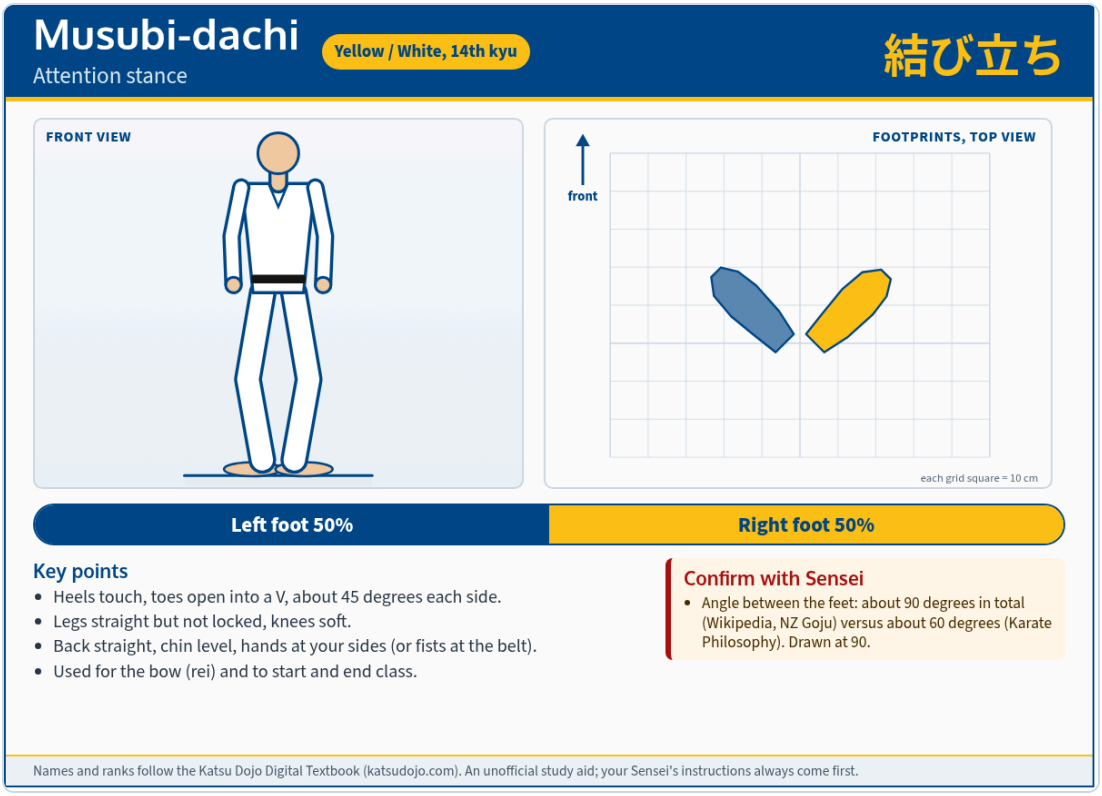
Kihon: everything required by black belt

Tachikata (stances), 13

- **Musubi**: Attention stance
- **Yoi**: Natural stance
- **Zenkutsu**: Front stance
- **Shiko**: Wide stance
- **Hanzenkutsu**: Half-front stance
- **Neko Ashi**: Cat stance
- **Kosa**: "X" stance
- **Heisoku**: Feet-together stance
- **Kokutsu**: Back stance
- **Re No Ji**: V-stance
- **Sachin**: Confirm with Sensei (not defined in the written tests)
- **Ten No Ji**: "T" stance
- **Sagi Ashi**: Crane foot stance

Stance pictures

Each card shows the figure, the footprints on a 10 cm grid (facing up), the weight split and the key points. Drawn from Shito-ryu sources first; where sources differ the card says **Confirm with Sensei**. A one-page version is in stance-reference-sheet.pdf on the site.

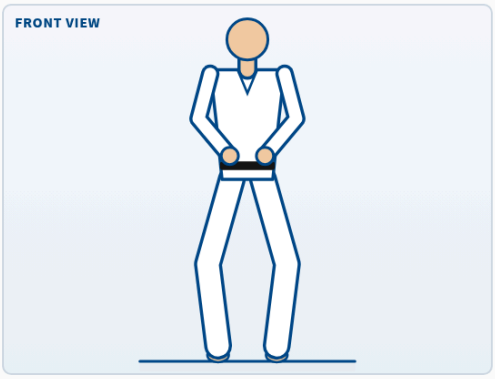


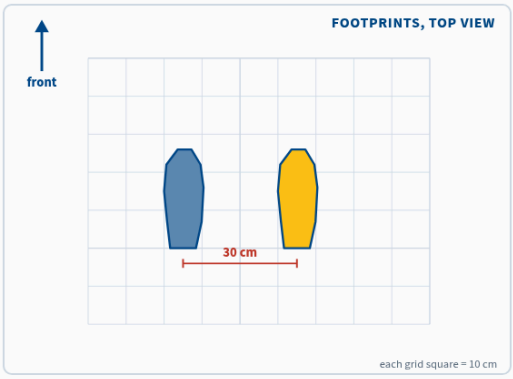
Yoi-dachi

Natural stance

Yellow / White, 14th kyu

用意立ち





Left foot 50% | **Right foot 50%**

Key points

- Feet about shoulder width apart, ready position.
- Knees slightly bent and relaxed, not locked.
- Weight even on both feet, back straight, eyes forward.
- Fists held low in front of the belt.

Confirm with Sensei

- Foot angle: parallel to slightly turned in (CFTS, Seitoshitoryu 'heiko'), versus about 30 degrees out (Karate Philosophy) or 45 degrees out (Wikipedia 'hachiji'). Drawn parallel.

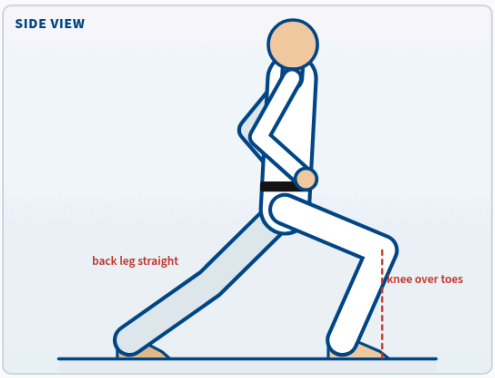
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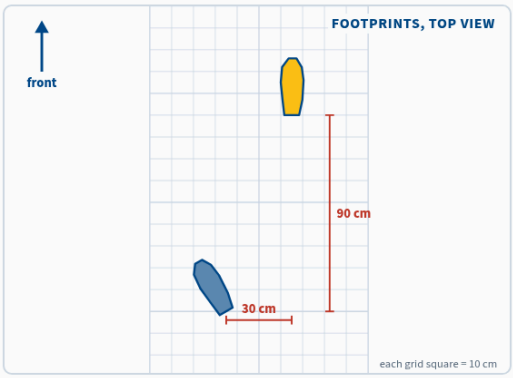
Zenkutsu-dachi

Front stance

Yellow / White, 14th kyu

前屈立ち





Front leg 60% | **Back leg 40%**

Key points

- Front knee bent so it sits over the toes; back leg straight.
- Feet as wide as your shoulders; heels about 2 shoulder widths apart (shin plus one foot, toe to heel).
- Hips and belly button face forward; back foot turned out about 30 to 45 degrees, heel down.
- Katsu's four rules: front leg bent, back leg straight, feet shoulder wide, hips forward.

Confirm with Sensei

- Weight split: 50/50 (seishin-kan Shito-ryu), 60/40 (Nakayama, NZ Goju, UoA) or 70/30 (CFTS). Drawn 60/40.
- Back foot angle: 30 degrees (Wikipedia) or 45 degrees (Seitoshitoryu summary).

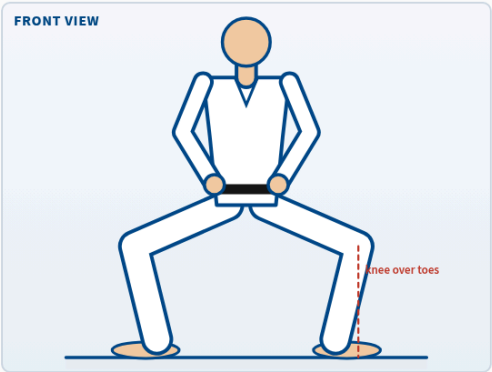
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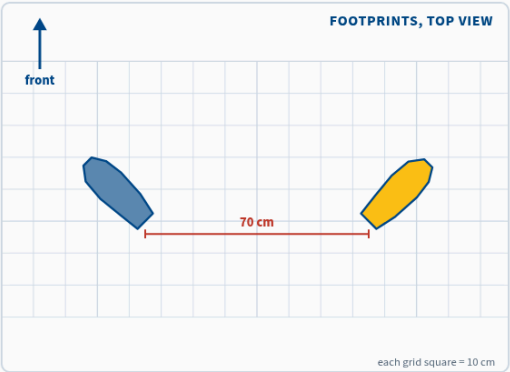
Shiko-dachi

Wide stance

Yellow / White, 14th kyu

四股立ち





Left leg 50% | **Right leg 50%**

Key points

- Feet about 2 shoulder widths apart, toes turned out about 45 degrees.
- Knees bent over the toes and pushed out; shins close to vertical.
- Hips low, thighs close to parallel with the floor, back straight.
- Weight even on both legs.

Sources agree

The Shito-ryu and general sources compared all describe this stance the same way. Your Sensei still has the last word.

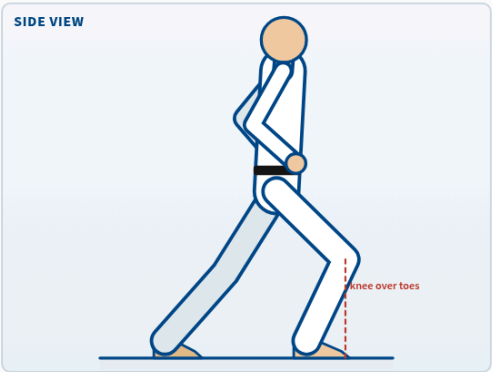
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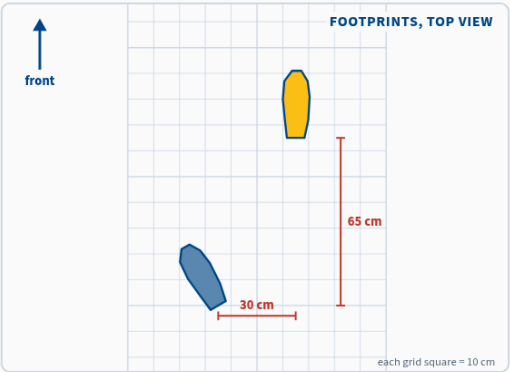
Hanzenkutsu-dachi

Half-front stance

Yellow, 13th kyu

半前屈立ち





Front leg 50% | **Back leg 50%**

Key points

- A shortened, higher zenkutsu: about 65 cm heel to heel.
- Front knee bent so the toes are hidden; back leg straight.
- Hips face forward; feet about shoulder width apart.
- Easier to move and kick from than full zenkutsu.

Confirm with Sensei

- Weight and exact length are not given in the Shito-ryu sources. NZ Goju says even weight; Wikipedia (moto-dachi, shin length) is similar. Drawn 50/50.

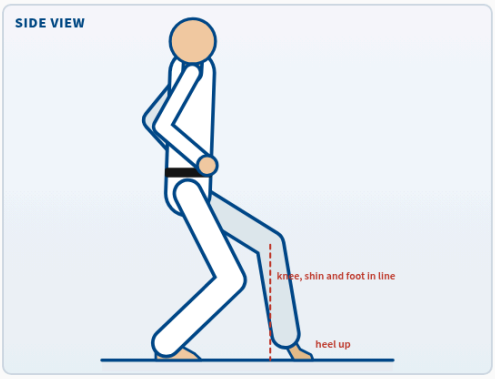
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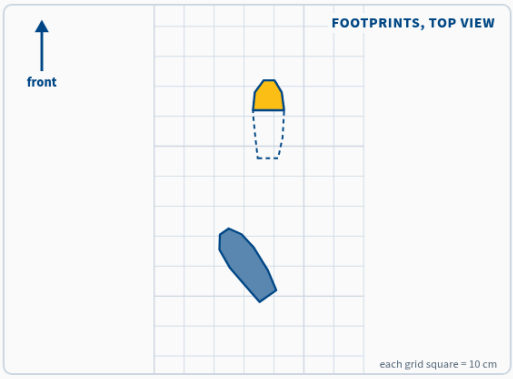
Neko Ashi-dachi

Cat stance

Orange / White, 12th kyu

猫足立ち





Back leg 80% | **Front foot 20%**

Key points

- Front heel raised; only the ball and toes touch the floor, pointing forward.
- Back foot flat and turned out 30 to 45 degrees; back knee bent as if sitting on a stool.
- Heel of the back foot to the ball of the front foot is about 2.5 foot lengths.
- Front knee over the big toe; body turned about 45 degrees (hanmi).

Confirm with Sensei

- Weight on the back leg: 70 to 80% (seishin-kan Shito-ryu) versus 90% (CFTS, NZ Goju). Drawn 80/20.

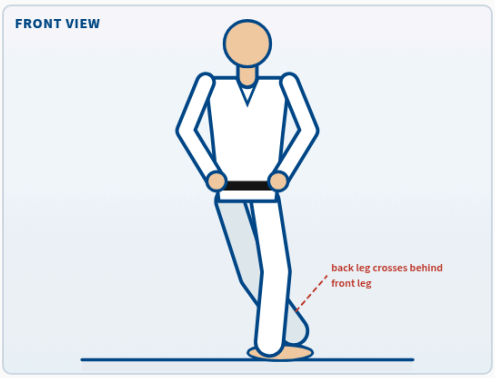
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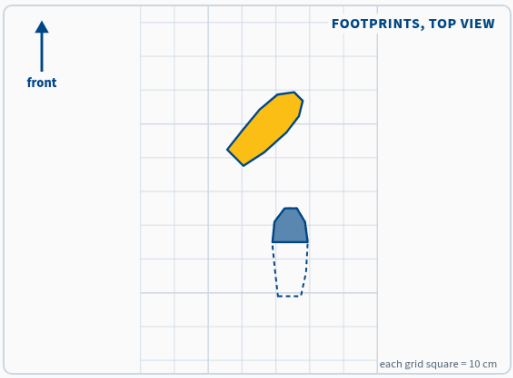
Kosa-dachi

"X" stance (crossed-leg stance)

Orange / White, 12th kyu

交差立ち





Front leg 90% | **Back leg 10%**

Key points

- The back leg crosses behind the front leg, forming an X.
- Back knee tucks in behind the front knee; only the ball and toes of the back foot touch.
- Front foot flat, turned out about 45 degrees.
- Most weight stays on the front leg; torso upright.

Confirm with Sensei

- Only one source (CFTS) gives a weight split (90/10). Foot angle varies by style, and the back foot may be directly behind or out to the side. Drawn behind and across.

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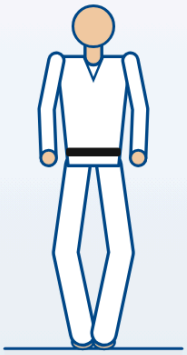
Heisoku-dachi

Feet-together stance

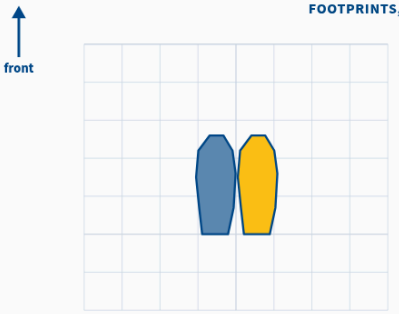
Orange, 11th kyu

閉足立ち

FRONT VIEW



FOOTPRINTS, TOP VIEW



Left foot 50%	Right foot 50%

Key points

- Feet together, toes and heels touching, pointing straight forward.
- Legs straight and relaxed.
- Often a transition stance, and the ready position in some kata.
- Weight even on both feet.

Sources agree

The Shito-ryu and general sources compared all describe this stance the same way. Your Sensei still has the last word.

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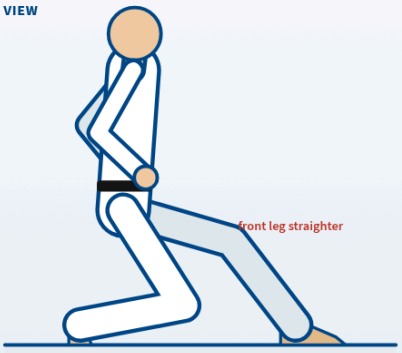
Kokutsu-dachi

Back stance

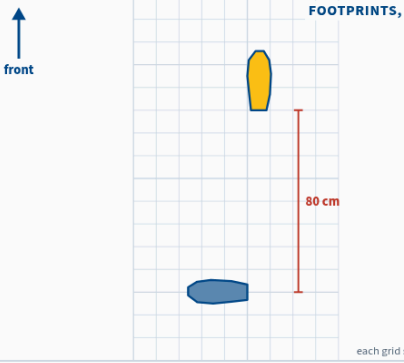
Blue / White, 8th kyu

後屈立ち

SIDE VIEW



FOOTPRINTS, TOP VIEW



Back leg 70%	Front leg 30%

Key points

- Back knee deeply bent with most weight on it; front leg straight or only slightly bent.
- Back foot turned out 90 degrees; front foot points forward.
- About 2 shoulder widths between the feet; a line from the back heel touches the inside of the front foot.
- Back straight and upright; hips turned about 45 degrees.

Confirm with Sensei

- Weight: most sources say 70/30; one measurement study and Impaku give about 67/33. Drawn 70/30.
- Front leg straight versus slightly bent depends on the style.

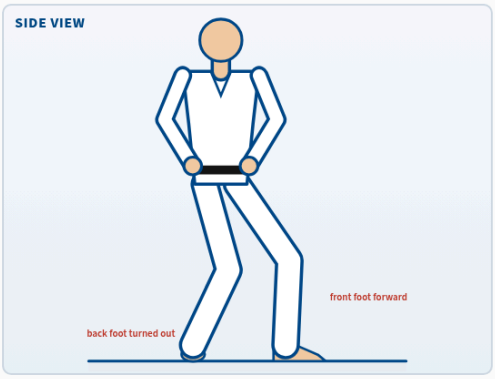
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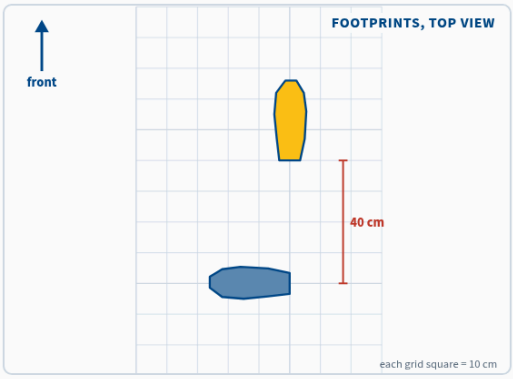
Re No Ji-dachi

Green / White, 6th kyu

V-stance (the letter L)

レの字立ち





Back leg 70% | **Front leg 30%**

Key points

- Front foot points forward; back foot turned out 90 degrees.
- If you slide the front foot straight back, its heel touches the heel of the back foot.
- The footprint looks like the katakana letter Re (or an L); Seitoshitoryu calls it a tilted V.
- Legs relaxed and almost straight, knees soft; back straight.

Confirm with Sensei

- Back foot angle: 90 degrees (Wikipedia, Karatedo Preschool, Shotokan Blackbelt IE) versus 45 degrees (NZ Goju, Karate Philosophy). Drawn 90.
- Weight: 70% on the back leg (Wikipedia) versus 50/50 (CFTS). Drawn 70/30.

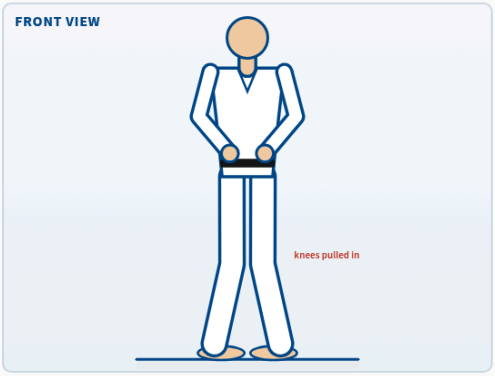
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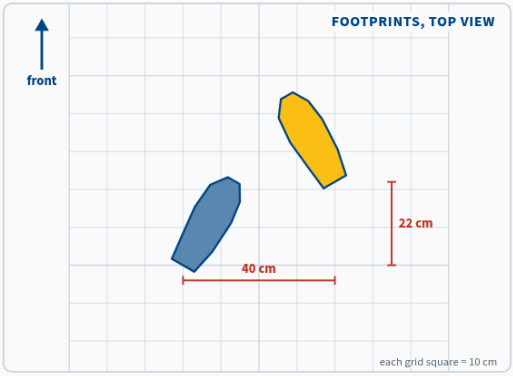
Sachin-dachi (Sanchin?)

Green / Brown, 4th kyu

Hourglass stance (confirm with Sensei)

三戦立ち





Left foot 50% | **Right foot 50%**

Key points

- Drawn as Sanchin-dachi, the hourglass stance: feet shoulder width, toes turned in.
- Toes of the back foot line up with the heel of the front foot.
- Knees pulled inward, buttocks tight, pelvis pushed slightly forward.
- Weight even; keep strong tension in the legs and belly (tanden).

Confirm with Sensei

- The Katsu textbook spells this 'Sachin' and does not define it. Drawn as Sanchin-dachi, the Shito-ryu hourglass stance.
- Toe-in angle: 30 to 45 degrees (Wikipedia, shitoryu.org) or only slightly in (NZ Goju). Drawn 30.

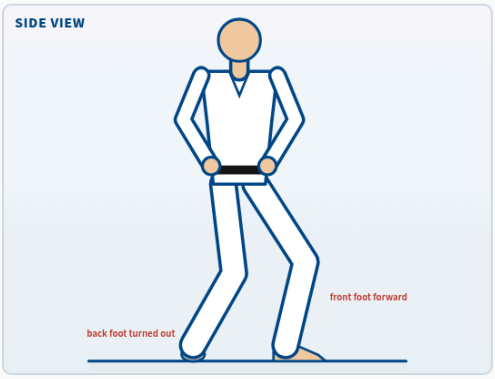
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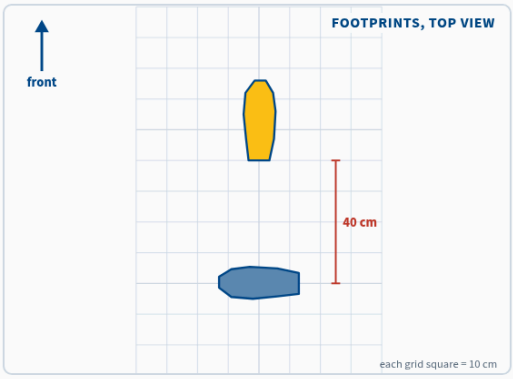
Ten No Ji-dachi

"T" stance

Brown / White, 3rd kyu

丁字立ち





Back leg 50% | **Front leg 50%**

Key points

- Front foot points forward; back foot turned out 90 degrees.
- Slide the front foot straight back and its heel touches the middle of the back foot.
- The footprint looks like a T (teiji-dachi in most sources).
- Legs relaxed and almost straight; weight about even.

Confirm with Sensei

- Katsu spells it 'Ten No Ji' (the other sources call it Teiji-dachi, 丁字立ち). Only CFTS gives a weight split (50/50); Wikipedia gives none.

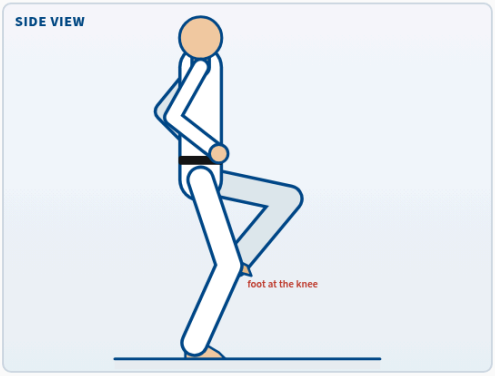
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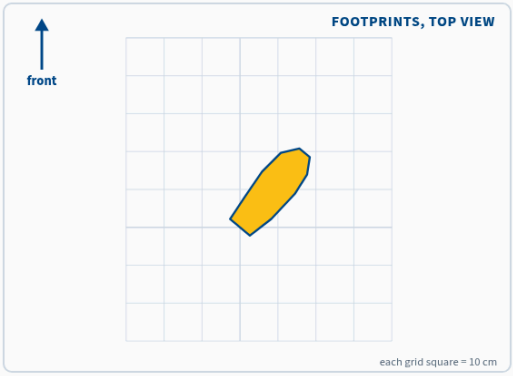
Sagi Ashi-dachi

Crane foot stance (heron foot)

Brown, 2nd kyu

鷺足立ち





Standing leg 100%

Key points

- Stand on one leg, knee slightly bent, foot turned out a little.
- The other foot is raised and touches the knee of the standing leg.
- Thigh of the raised leg points forward, close to level.
- Where the foot touches the knee (inside or behind) differs by style and kata.

Confirm with Sensei

- Exact contact point between the foot and the knee varies by style and by kata (for example Rohai versus Jitte).

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Tanren Ho (exercises)

- 10 Udetate Seiken (knuckle pushups)
- 10 Sanbon Geri (three front kicks)
- 10 Suwari Geri (squat kicks)

Kihon Waza (basic techniques), 18

1. Shiko-Dachi Chudan-Zuki
2. Zenkutsu-Dachi Chudan-Zuki
3. Zenkutsu-Dachi Chudan-Geri Chudan-Zuki
4. Sokuto Kansetsu-Geri
5. Ten Shin
6. Zenkutsu-Dachi Gyakuzuki
7. Yoko-Geri
8. Kumite Style Gyakuzuki
9. Kumite Style Mawashi-Geri
10. Ushiro-Geri
11. Spinning Kentsui
12. Ura Mawashi-Geri
13. Spinning Ushiro-Geri
14. Kumite Style Ten Shin
15. Tobi Nidan-Geri
16. Shiko-Dachi Kakate
17. Spinning Mawashi-Geri
18. Spinning Ura Mawashi-Geri

Kumite

Jyu Kumite (free sparring): one round from Orange through Green/Brown, then two rounds from Brown/White on.

Rank by rank: what each rank adds

Rank	New stances	New techniques	Kata tested	Kumite
Yellow / White 14th Kyu	Musubi, Yoi, Zenkutsu, Shiko	Shiko-Dachi Chudan-Zuki, Zenkutsu-Dachi Chudan-Zuki, Zenkutsu-Dachi Chudan-Geri Chudan-Zuki	Shiho No Kata	—
Yellow 13th Kyu	Hanzenkutsu	Sokuto Kansetsu-Geri, Ten Shin, Zenkutsu-Dachi Gyakuzuki	Shiho No Kata + Ten No Kata	—
Orange / White 12th Kyu	Neko Ashi, Kosa	Yoko-Geri	Ten No Kata + Kihon No Kata	—
Orange 11th Kyu	Heisoku	Kumite Style Gyakuzuki	Kihon No Kata + Chi No Kata	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Purple / White 10th Kyu	—	Kumite Style Mawashi-Geri	Chi No Kata + Heian Shodan	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Purple 9th Kyu	—	Ushiro-Geri	Heian Shodan + Heian Nidan	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Blue / White 8th Kyu	Kokutsu	Spinning Kentsui	Heian Nidan + Heian Sandan	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Blue 7th Kyu	—	Ura Mawashi-Geri	Heian Sandan + Heian Yondan	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Green / White 6th Kyu	Re No Ji	Spinning Ushiro-Geri	Heian Yondan + Heian Godan	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Green 5th Kyu	—	Kumite Style Ten Shin	Heian Godan + Jitte	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Green / Brown 4th Kyu	Sachin	Tobi Nidan-Geri	Jitte + Jin	Jyu Kumite (one round)
Brown / White 3rd Kyu	Ten No Ji	Shiko-Dachi Kakate	Jin + Jion	Jyu Kumite (two rounds)
Brown 2nd Kyu	Sagi Ashi	Spinning Mawashi-Geri	Jion + Jyuroku	Jyu Kumite (two rounds)

Brown / Black 1st Kyu	—	Spinning Ura Mawashi-Geri	Jyuroku + Rohai	Jyu Kumite (two rounds)

6-Week Study Plan

Week 1: Shiho, Ten, Kihon and Chi No Kata; all 13 stances; the 3 Tanren Ho exercises; Basics and Stances flashcards.

Week 2: Heian Shodan to Godan; techniques 1–9; Terms and Body flashcards.

Week 3: Jitte, Jin and Jion; techniques 10–18; Kumite and Language flashcards; Jyu Kumite rounds.

Week 4: Jyuroku and Rohai; spinning and jumping kicks; History and Dojo flashcards.

Week 5: All 14 kata in order, judged against the 7 kata criteria; full kihon run; take the quiz until you score 100%.

Week 6: Mock test with a partner asking the questions in random order (like the oral test); help in beginner and intermediate classes; ask your instructor for a pre-test review.

A suggested plan, not part of the official requirements.

Written Test Questions & Answers

1. **What type of martial art do you study?**
   Karate
2. **What does karate mean?**
   Empty hand
3. **What country does karate come from?**
   Japan
4. **What are the three rules of karate?**
   1) Listen and pay attention in class; 2) Try your best in class; 3) Never use your karate on anyone unless you're defending yourself
5. **What part of the hand do you punch with?**
   The first two knuckles
6. **Do down-block, head-block and side-block come from the inside or outside?**
   Down-block: inside; head-block: inside; side-block: outside
7. **What are the four motions of a kick?**
   Up, out, back, down
8. **What are the four rules for zenkutsu-dachi?**
   Front leg bent; back leg straight; hips facing forward; feet as wide as your shoulders
9. **What style of karate do you study?**
   Shito-Ryu
10. **Who is the founder of Shito-Ryu?**
    Kenwa Mabuni
11. **What island in Japan does karate originate from?**
    Okinawa
12. **What is a tsuki?**
    Punch
13. **What is a keri?**
    Kick
14. **What does musubi-dachi mean?**
    Attention stance
15. **What does yoi-dachi mean?**
    Natural stance
16. **What does zenkutsu-dachi mean?**
    Front stance
17. **What does shiko-dachi mean?**
    Wide stance
18. **What does hanzenkutsu-dachi mean?**
    Half-front stance
19. **What does neko ashi-dachi mean?**
    Cat stance
20. **What does kosa-dachi mean?**
    "X" stance

21. **What are the five Katsu Dojo Virtues?**
    Courage, Courtesy, Integrity, Humility, Self-Control
22. **What does udetate seiken mean?**
    Knuckle pushups
23. **What does suwari-geri mean?**
    Squat kicks
24. **What does heisoku-dachi mean?**
    Feet-together stance
25. **What does gyaku-zuki mean?**
    Reverse punch
26. **What does awase-zuki mean?**
    "U" punch
27. **What is an empi?**
    Elbow strike
28. **What are the three reasons that we kiai?**
    Scare your opponent; tighten your stomach; increase personal energy
29. **What is a gedan-barai?**
    Down-block
30. **What is an age-uke?**
    Head-block
31. **What is a yoko-uke?**
    Side-block
32. **Atama, Te, Ude, Ashi, Hiza?**
    Head, hand, arm, foot or leg, knee
33. **What does kumite mean?**
    Sparring
34. **What does hajime mean?**
    Begin
35. **What does yame mean?**
    Stop
36. **What is a mawashi-geri?**
    Roundhouse kick
37. **What is a jodan-zuki?**
    Head punch
38. **What is a chudan-zuki?**
    Center punch
39. **What is a shuto?**
    Chop
40. **What does Nage Waza mean?**
    Take down (the Purple/White test spells it "Naga Waza")
41. **Konnichi wa, Sayonara, Ohayo gozaimasu, Konban wa?**
    Hello, goodbye, good morning, good evening
42. **What do migi and hidari mean?**
    Migi: right; hidari: left

43. **How do you say "thank you very much" in Japanese?**
    Domo arigato gozaimasu
44. **How do you say "please" in Japanese?**
    Dozo
45. **What does ippon mean?**
    Full point
46. **What does waza ari mean?**
    Half point
47. **What do aka and shiro mean?**
    Aka: red; shiro: white
48. **What is an ushiro-geri?**
    Back kick
49. **What is an uchiotoshi?**
    Elbow & hammer fist block
50. **Mune, Onaka, Hiji, Kubi, Senaka?**
    Chest, stomach, elbow, neck, back
51. **What part of the foot is in contact with the floor when moving in kumite?**
    Ball of foot
52. **What kumite equipment must you wear during sparring?**
    Hand pads, mouth guard, shin/foot guards, head gear (kids only), groin cup (males only)
53. **What does kokutsu-dachi mean?**
    Back stance
54. **What is an ashi-barai?**
    Leg sweep
55. **What is a kentsui?**
    Hammer fist
56. **What is a nukite?**
    Spear hand
57. **What do ue, shita, uchi and soto mean?**
    Above, below, inside, outside
58. **What are the seven criteria for a good kata performance?**
    Correct breathing, power, speed, timing, balance, focus, fighting spirit
59. **What part of the foot do you strike with in mawashi-geri?**
    Top of foot
60. **How do you say "I'm sorry" in Japanese?**
    Gomen nasai
61. **What is an ura mawashi-geri?**
    Reverse roundhouse kick
62. **What is an uraken?**
    Back fist (the Blue test spells it "udaken")
63. **What is a kosa-uke?**
    X-block
64. **What is a soe-uke?**
    Reinforced side-block

65. **What are the six techniques in a good sparring punch or kick?**
    Good form, correct attitude, vigorous application, zanshin (perfect finish), proper timing, correct distance
66. **Ago, Nodo, Hana, Mimi, Me?**
    Chin, throat, nose, ears, eyes
67. **How many points do you need to win a shobu sanbon kumite match?**
    Three
68. **What does re no ji-dachi mean?**
    V-stance
69. **What are the four major karate styles in the world?**
    Shito-Ryu, Shotokan, Goju-Ryu, Wado-Ryu
70. **Count from one to ten.**
    Ichi, ni, san, shi, go, roku, shichi, hachi, kyu, jyu
71. **Ashikubi, Ashiyubi, Yubi, Kakato, Tekubi?**
    Ankles, toes, finger, heel, wrist
72. **What part of the foot do you use with an ushiro-geri?**
    Heel
73. **Kuroi, Chairo, Orenji, Akai, Kiiroi, Aoi, Midori, Murasaki, Shiroi?**
    Black, brown, orange, red, yellow, blue, green, purple, white
74. **What is a shote?**
    Palm strike
75. **What is a tobi nidan-geri?**
    Jumping double kick
76. **What part of your opponent's leg do you target for a leg-sweep?**
    Ankle area
77. **What is the purpose of Ten Shin?**
    Step out of the way of an attacker
78. **What is a yoko-barai?**
    Side hammerfist block
79. **Who is the founder of Shotokan?**
    Gichin Funakoshi
80. **What does Bunkai & Oyo mean?**
    Explanation & application
81. **What is the major style of Chinese martial arts, and what does it mean?**
    Kung Fu: "to be skillful"
82. **What is the major style of Korean martial arts, and what does it mean?**
    Tae Kwon Do: "kick punch way"
83. **What type of punch does the attacker use in Take Down #7?**
    Head punch
84. **What is a kakate?**
    Arm grab
85. **Who is the founder of Goju-Ryu, and what does Goju-Ryu mean?**
    Chojun Miyagi; "hard-soft way"
86. **Who were Kenwa Mabuni's two main instructors?**
    Yasutsune (Anko) Itosu and Kanryo Higaonna

87. **What does menjo mean?**
    Diploma
88. **What three regions of Okinawa were the three original karate styles named after?**
    Naha, Shuri, Tomari
89. **What does ten no ji-dachi mean?**
    "T" stance
90. **What is sagi ashi-dachi?**
    Crane foot stance
91. **Who is the founder of Wado-Ryu, and what does Wado-Ryu mean?**
    Hironori Ohtsuka; "way of peace"
92. **What two kicks are used in Moving Exercise #2?**
    Mae-geri and yoko-geri
93. **What part of the foot do you strike with in ura mawashi-geri?**
    Bottom of foot
94. **What is shomen?**
    The front of a dojo
95. **What martial art organization is Katsu Dojo a member of?**
    USA National Karate-Do Federation
96. **What is the purpose of Katsu Dojo's Todi?**
    Black-belt entrance
97. **Name all 14 kata in order, with their meanings.**
    1. Shiho No Kata (Four Direction Kata); 2. Ten No Kata (Heavenly Kata); 3. Kihon No Kata (Basic Kata); 4. Chi No Kata (Earth Kata); 5. Heian Shodan (Peaceful Mind #1); 6. Heian Nidan (Peaceful Mind #2); 7. Heian Sandan (Peaceful Mind #3); 8. Heian Yondan (Peaceful Mind #4); 9. Heian Godan (Peaceful Mind #5); 10. Jitte (Ten Hands); 11. Jin (Named after a spirit); 12. Jion (Named after a temple in China (its temple of origin)); 13. Jyuroku (Sixteen); 14. Rohai (Vision of a white heron)
98. **What does Shiho No Kata mean?**
    Four Direction Kata
99. **What does Ten No Kata mean?**
    Heavenly Kata
100. **What does Kihon No Kata mean?**
    Basic Kata
101. **What does Chi No Kata mean?**
    Earth Kata
102. **What does Heian Shodan mean?**
    Peaceful Mind #1
103. **What does Heian Nidan mean?**
    Peaceful Mind #2
104. **What does Heian Sandan mean?**
    Peaceful Mind #3
105. **What does Heian Yondan mean?**
    Peaceful Mind #4
106. **What does Heian Godan mean?**
    Peaceful Mind #5

07. **What does Jitte mean?**
    Ten Hands
08. **What does Jin mean?**
    Named after a spirit
09. **What does Jion mean?**
    Named after a temple in China (its temple of origin)
10. **What does Jyuroku mean?**
    Sixteen
11. **What does Rohai mean?**
    Vision of a white heron

Based on the Katsu Dojo Digital Textbook (katsudojo.com). An unofficial study aid; your Sensei's instructions always come first.